

D836

Social Studies Methods II

Armored Drill

8 concepts · 12 items · 4 transfer items

What this is. Every concept in this course's public description, re-asked with more disguise than a practice test uses. Each stem carries facts that do not decide it. Every wrong answer is a named trap.

Source. Scope from the course's public description in the WGU Institutional Catalog (September 2026); items written from the field's standard body of knowledge. No WGU assessment item, course material or proprietary content is used or reproduced. Not affiliated with or endorsed by Western Governors University.

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How to run it

Paper first. Pencil. One pass, no notes, a timer if you want the pressure.

1. **Before you read the options**, fill the strip under the item: the target word (what is actually being asked), and the one fact in the stem that decides it.
2. **Principle before arithmetic**. Name the rule, then compute.
3. **Camouflage**. Most of every stem does not matter. Ask: which single fact decides this?
4. **Inverse pairs are the bait**. If two options are opposites, one of them is the trap built for you.
5. **Mark sure, unsure or guess** honestly. Sure-and-wrong is the most valuable miss on the page — it is a wrong mental model.
6. **Absolutes** (always, never, guarantee) are usually wrong. And recognizing an answer is not the same as owning it.
7. Items with a **heavy black bar** on the left are **transfer items**: the same principle, reversed or solved for a different variable.
8. Stop at the STOP page. Then grade, fill the triage grid, and tally the traps you fell for. The biggest tally is what you drill next.

The strip, filled in, looks like this:

Target word _____	The one fact that decides _____	Answer _____	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
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Items

1.

A government teacher whose classroom has new flexible seating uses a lesson on whether voting should be required. Pairs first argue for, then switch and argue against, then work together to write a statement they both agree with. The school just hired a new principal. Which strategy is this?

- A. Flexible seating grouping.
- B. A formal debate.
- C. Structured Academic Controversy.
- D. A Socratic seminar.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

2.

A student in an economics class paid a \$150 nonrefundable deposit for a summer camp. She now gets a job offer that pays \$600 for the same weeks. The camp would give her benefits she values at \$400, and the camp is known for its beautiful lake. Using marginal thinking, what should she do?

- A. Take the job, because it gives \$600 compared with \$400 of value from camp; the \$150 is sunk.
- B. Go to camp, because of the lake.
- C. Go to camp, because $\$400 + \$150 = \$550$ is close to \$600.
- D. Go to camp, so the \$150 deposit is not wasted.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

3. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

A student already paid a \$200 nonrefundable fee for a trip. A job offers \$500 for the same week. What is the smallest value the trip must have to her for going on the trip to be the better choice?

- A. More than \$500.
- B. More than \$700.
- C. More than \$200.
- D. More than \$300.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

4.

An economics teacher who used to work at a bank asks students to explain what happens to the demand for tacos when the price of tacos falls from \$4 to \$3. The local taco shop recently opened a second location. Which answer is correct?

- A. Quantity demanded rises, a movement along the same demand curve.
- B. The demand curve shifts to the right.
- C. Supply shifts right because of the new location.
- D. Demand falls because the price fell.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

5. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

Incomes in a town rise, and people buy more tacos at every price. What happened?

- A. The supply curve shifted right.
- B. The demand curve shifted right.
- C. The demand curve shifted left.
- D. A movement along the demand curve.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

6.

In a comparative government unit, students study a country where the prime minister is the leader of the largest party in the legislature and can be removed by a vote of no confidence. The country has a long coastline and a strong fishing industry. What kind of system does this describe?

- A. Confederal.
- B. Presidential.
- C. Parliamentary.
- D. Unitary, because of the coastline.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

7. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

In which system is the head of government elected separately from the legislature for a fixed term?

- A.** Federal.
- B.** Presidential.
- C.** Every democracy.
- D.** Parliamentary.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

8.

A psychology class reads about a study that found students who eat breakfast earn higher grades. The researchers surveyed 2,000 students at a well-funded university. A student says, eating breakfast causes better grades. What should the teacher point out?

- A.** With 2,000 students, the result proves cause.
- B.** A correlational study cannot show cause; another factor, such as family routines, could explain both.
- C.** Better grades cause students to eat breakfast.
- D.** The results are valid because the university is well funded.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

9. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

A researcher wants to test whether eating breakfast causes higher test scores. Which design allows a causal conclusion?

- A.** Interview a few top students about their breakfast routines.
- B.** Let students choose whether to eat breakfast, then compare scores.
- C.** Survey a larger group about their breakfast habits and grades.
- D.** Randomly assign students to eat or skip breakfast before the same test and compare scores.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

10.

A world history teacher who recently traveled to Japan notes that one textbook starts the modern era in 1450 and another in 1750. The two textbooks have the same page count. What should students learn from this?

- A.** The dates are the same because the books are the same length.
- B.** One textbook must be wrong.
- C.** Dates in history do not matter.
- D.** Periodization reflects what historians think matters most, such as exploration vs. industrialization.

Target word _____	The one fact that decides _____	Answer ____	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
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11.

An economics teacher who coaches soccer starts a unit by asking: Our town's only grocery store is closing. What should the town do? Students must research and propose solutions. The class meets in the last period of the day. Which approach is this?

- A.** A test review game.
- B.** Direct instruction.
- C.** Problem-based learning.
- D.** A culminating project after all content is taught.

Target word _____	The one fact that decides _____	Answer ____	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
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12.

A student in a U.S. history class, who wrote neatly and finished early, answers a DBQ by summarizing Document 1, then Document 2, then Document 3, with no thesis. The question asks about causes of the Great Depression. What is the most important feedback?

- A.** Remove the documents and write from memory.
- B.** Add a summary of Documents 4 and 5.
- C.** Praise the neatness and early finish.
- D.** Write a thesis that answers the question, then group documents as evidence for each part of the argument.

Target word _____	The one fact that decides _____	Answer ____	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
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STOP

Answers and dissection follow. Finish every item and every strip first.

Key and dissection

Struck-through text is the camouflage: facts that do not decide the item.

1. Answer C Concept 1

A government teacher ~~whose classroom has new flexible seating~~ uses a lesson on whether voting should be required. Pairs first argue for, then switch and argue against, then work together to write a statement they both agree with. ~~The school just hired a new principal.~~ Which strategy is this?

Target word: name the discourse strategy **Decides:** Switching sides and seeking consensus.

A	Camouflage	Seating is not a discourse strategy.
B	Confusion set	Debate has fixed sides and a winner.
C	Correct	Argue, switch, and move toward consensus.
D	Adjacent category	Seminar centers open questions on a text, without assigned sides.

2. Answer A Concept 2

A student in an economics class paid a \$150 nonrefundable deposit for a summer camp. She now gets a job offer that pays \$600 for the same weeks. The camp would give her benefits she values at \$400, ~~and the camp is known for its beautiful lake.~~ Using marginal thinking, what should she do?

Target word: decision with a sunk cost **Decides:** The \$150 is sunk; compare \$400 benefit vs. \$600 given up.

A	Correct	Ignore the sunk cost; the job's marginal benefit is higher.
B	Camouflage	The lake is already part of her \$400 value.
C	Wrong stem number	Adds the unrecoverable deposit to the camp's value.
D	Inverted operation	Lets the sunk cost drive the decision.

3. Answer A Concept 2 • transfer

A student already paid a \$200 nonrefundable fee for a trip. A job offers \$500 for the same week. What is the smallest value the trip must have to her for going on the trip to be the better choice?

Target word: solve for the break-even value **Decides:** The trip must beat the \$500 given up; the \$200 is sunk.

A	Correct	Her opportunity cost is the \$500 wage; the fee is irrelevant.
B	Wrong stem number	Adds the sunk fee to the wage.
C	Dropped element	Ignores the job she gives up.
D	Inverted operation	Subtracts the sunk fee from the wage.

4. Answer A Concept 3

An economics teacher ~~who used to work at a bank~~ asks students to explain what happens to the demand for tacos when the price of tacos falls from \$4 to \$3. ~~The local taco shop recently opened a second location.~~ Which answer is correct?

Target word: movement vs. shift **Decides:** The good's own price changed.

A	Correct	Own-price changes move along the curve.
B	Confusion set	Shifts come from factors other than own price.
C	Camouflage	The question is about demand after a price change.
D	Inverted operation	Lower price increases quantity demanded.

5. Answer B Concept 3 • transfer

Incomes in a town rise, and people buy more tacos at every price. What happened?

Target word: reverse: non-price cause **Decides:** Income, not price, changed.

A	Adjacent category	Income affects buyers, not sellers.
B	Correct	A change in income shifts the curve for a normal good.
C	Inverted operation	More is bought at every price, so it shifts right.
D	Confusion set	Movements are caused only by own-price changes.

6. Answer C Concept 4

In a comparative government unit, students study a country where the prime minister is the leader of the largest party in the legislature and can be removed by a vote of no confidence. ~~The country has a long coastline and a strong fishing industry.~~ What kind of system does this describe?

Target word: classify the system **Decides:** The executive comes from and answers to the legislature.

A	Adjacent category	That describes how power is divided among levels, not branches.
B	Confusion set	A presidential executive has a fixed, separate term.
C	Correct	The executive depends on legislative confidence.
D	Camouflage	Geography does not decide the system.

7. Answer B Concept 4 • transfer

In which system is the head of government elected separately from the legislature for a fixed term?

Target word: reverse **Decides:** Separate election and fixed term.

A	Adjacent category	Describes national and state power, not the executive.
B	Correct	Separation of executive and legislature.
C	Absolute language	Many democracies are parliamentary.
D	Inverted operation	The executive comes from the legislature.

8. Answer B Concept 5

A psychology class reads about a study that found students who eat breakfast earn higher grades. The researchers surveyed 2,000 students ~~at a well-funded university.~~ A student says, eating breakfast causes better grades. What should the teacher point out?

Target word: can we claim cause **Decides:** Variables were measured, not manipulated.

A	Absolute language	Sample size does not turn correlation into causation.
B	Correct	Only an experiment with random assignment supports causation.
C	Inverted operation	Reverses the claim but still assumes cause.
D	Camouflage	Funding does not decide design.

9. Answer D Concept 5 · transfer

A researcher wants to test whether eating breakfast causes higher test scores. Which design allows a causal conclusion?

Target word: design that supports cause **Decides:** Manipulating the variable with random assignment.

A	Adjacent category	A case study cannot show cause.
B	Dropped element	Drops random assignment, so self-selection remains.
C	Confusion set	Still correlational, only bigger.
D	Correct	An experiment with random assignment controls third variables.

10. Answer D Concept 6

A world history teacher ~~who recently traveled to Japan~~ notes that one textbook starts the modern era in 1450 and another in 1750. ~~The two textbooks have the same page count.~~ What should students learn from this?

Target word: meaning of different start dates **Decides:** Choices about periods reflect interpretations.

A	Camouflage	Page count is irrelevant.
B	Absolute language	Both are defensible interpretations.
C	Inverted operation	Dates matter; their meaning is interpreted.
D	Correct	Period boundaries are interpretive choices.

11. Answer C Concept 7

An economics teacher ~~who coaches soccer~~ starts a unit by asking: Our town's only grocery store is closing. What should the town do? Students must research and propose solutions. ~~The class meets in the last period of the day.~~ Which approach is this?

Target word: identify PBL **Decides:** A real, open problem launches learning.

A	Camouflage	Not a real problem.
B	Adjacent category	Content is not delivered first.
C	Correct	An ill-structured real problem drives inquiry.
D	Inverted operation	Here the problem comes first.

12. Answer D Concept 8

A student in a U.S. history class, ~~who wrote neatly and finished early,~~ answers a DBQ by summarizing Document 1, then Document 2, then Document 3, with no thesis. The question asks about causes of the Great Depression. What is the most important feedback?

Target word: DBQ feedback **Decides:** No thesis and no grouping of evidence.

A	Inverted operation	Drops the evidence.
B	Dropped element	More summary without a thesis.
C	Camouflage	Presentation is not the issue.
D	Correct	Argument and grouping are the core of a DBQ.

Triage grid

Write each item number in the box it belongs to.

	Right	Wrong
Sure	Owned.	Concept inversion — top priority. A wrong mental model; it survives rewording.
Unsure / guess	Recognition, not mastery. Re-drill with the transfer.	Not learned yet.

Trap tally

For every miss, find the letter you chose in the key and tally its trap. The biggest number is the pattern to drill.

Trap	What it does	In this drill	Your misses
Dropped element	Leaves out a required term or step.	3	
Wrong stem number	A figure copied from the prompt that is not the answer.	2	
Adjacent category	The right idea in the wrong bucket.	6	
Inverted operation	Direction flipped: add/subtract, cause/effect, higher/lower.	9	
Absolute language	Always, never, guarantee — where judgment applies.	3	
Confusion set	Every option is real; the test is exact role-matching.	5	
Camouflage	Answers a stem fact that was never the question.	8	

Anchor rows — the concept list

One row per concept: the rule to lock in, the trap that catches people, and the tell in the question that signals it.

#	Concept	Rule	Trap	Tell
1	Structured Academic Controversy	In SAC, pairs argue one side, switch and argue the other, then drop roles to seek consensus, building civic discourse rather than winning.	Treating SAC as a debate with winners and losers.	Students switch positions and then look for agreement.
2	Marginal thinking and sunk costs	Rational decisions compare the additional benefit with the additional cost; money already spent that cannot be recovered is ignored.	Letting sunk costs drive the next decision.	Money already spent plus a choice about the next step.
3	Shift vs. movement along a demand curve	A change in the good's own price moves along the demand curve; changes in income, tastes, related goods, or expectations shift the whole curve.	Saying a price change shifts demand.	Whether the cause is the good's own price or something else.
4	Parliamentary vs. presidential systems	In a parliamentary system the executive comes from and answers to the legislature; in a presidential system the executive is separately elected with a fixed term.	Assuming every democracy separates the executive and legislature.	How the head of government is chosen or removed.
5	Correlation vs. causation in psychology	Only a controlled experiment with random assignment supports a causal claim; a correlation may reflect a third variable.	Reading a strong correlation as proof of cause.	A study that measures two variables without manipulating either.
6	Periodization is an interpretation	Where historians start and end a period reflects what they consider important, so different periodizations tell different stories.	Treating period dates as fixed facts.	Two textbooks draw a period's boundaries differently.
7	Problem-based learning	PBL starts with an ill-structured, real problem that drives students to learn content in order to propose solutions.	Teaching all the content first and adding a problem at the end.	The problem comes first and has no single right answer.
8	Document-based argument writing	A strong DBQ response makes a defensible thesis, groups documents as evidence, and explains each source's point of view or purpose.	Summarizing each document in order.	A response walks through Document 1, Document 2, and so on.

Course scope (public description): Social Studies Methods II prepares educators to employ effective teaching strategies for social studies in grades 10–12, including psychology, economics, US history II, world history II, and government/political science. Emphasizing inquiry-based learning and integrated approaches, the course addresses pedagogical considerations and content alignment specific to secondary education. Methods include teaching through big ideas, civic discourse, inquiry, and problem-solving. Candidates apply these strategies to design instruction that fosters students' understanding across social studies disciplines. The course integrates inquiry-based learning with historical analysis, examining global connections and governance systems.